Christopher Fickess

Senior Site Reliability Engineer (SRE) & Senior DevOps Engineer

Terraform | Kubernetes | GitOps | AWS | CI/CD | Ansible | Cloud Security

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Professional Summary

Accomplished Site Reliability Engineer (SRE) with 6+ years in Cloud Infrastructure & DevOps, including 3+ years leadings teams. Experienced in designing, deploying, & managing distributed systems across multi-account AWS environments with high-availability Kubernetes (EKS) clusters. Skilled in Terraform Infrastructure as Code (IaC), Ansible automation, GitOps pipelines & CI/CD systems. Strong background in cloud security & compliance (DoD IL5, FedRAMP, zero-trust, IAM least privilege, encryption). Proficient in monitoring & observability, logging, incident response, incident management, troubleshooting, & root cause analysis. Hands-on with networking, load balancing, disaster recovery, automated failover, & fault-tolerant design. Experienced in capacity management, performance tuning, & maintaining scalable, reliable, Linux virtualization & highly available systems. Mentor & technical leader driving DevOps adoption, automation, & continuous improvement.

Certifications

CompTIA Security+	June 30, 2025
Test Driven Development (TDD), and Refactoring Legacy Code Using Java	Aug 25, 2021
AWS Certified Cloud Practitioner	**In Progress**

Skills

Cloud	Aurora, AWS, EBS, EC2, EFS, EKS, IAM, Lambda, KMS, RDS, S3, VPC, Azure, Multi-tenant, Service Mesh, SQL/Postgres
Compliance	Container Vulnerability Scans, DAST, Egress, FedRAMP, Ingress, Linux, OS-Level Hardening, PowerShell, SAST, SeLinux, Unix
Containers	Buildah, Cluster Autoscaling, Docker, Flux, Gatekeeper (OPA), HA, Kustomize, kubectl, Kubernetes, Podman, Velero
DevOps	Confluence, Cost Optimization & Management, Git, GitLab CI/CD Pipelines, GitOps Workflows, Jira, Multi-AZ, Networking
Languages	Ansible, Bash, C#, CPP, Gradle, Go, HTML, Java, JavaScript, JSON, Make, Markdown, Perl, Python, Ruby, Terraform, XML, YAML
Monitoring	CloudTrail, CloudWatch, CompTIA Security+, Elasticsearch, Gatekeeper Policy, Go, Grafana, Prometheus, SLO/SLI, Splunk
Platform	GitLab, SonarQube, Nexus Repository, Nexus IQ, Twistlock, Kiali, Elasticsearch, Kibana, Grafana, Prometheus, Splunk
Security	Alerting Standard, Blameless Postmortem, Incident Response, Risk Management, OKTA, SAML, Security Best Practice, WAF

Work Experience

Boeing - *Senior Lead Site Reliability Engineer & Senior Lead Platform Engineer* — **Oct 10, 2022 - Nov 7, 2025**

Active US Security Clearance (Top Secret) — **Oklahoma City**, *OK*

- **Coached junior engineers on Infrastructure as Code (IaC) & Configuration as Code (CaC)** with Docker automation pipelines, reduced manual work, engineering hours, & deployment time by 40%, while enhancing AWS cloud capabilities across teams
- **Architected & operated multi-AZ GitOps Blue/Green Deployment Kubernetes clusters with Terraform**, implemented cloud architecture best practices for automation frameworks, security, networking, observability, scalability, & reliability by 10%
- **Led real-time incident response, troubleshooting, debugging, & root cause analysis during production outages**, leveraged expertise in DNS resolution, Istio Network Load Balancing & infrastructure to diagnose & resolve production outages, restored system availability & reinforced incident management best practices to improve on-call incident resolution efficiency
- **Drove cost reduction for Terraform-Managed EKS Kubernetes cluster by 35%, after migrating to Karpenter**, leveraging GitLab automation pipelines & dynamic scaling strategies to boost performance optimization & reliability under variable load
- **Implemented GitLab Advanced Search by deploying Elasticsearch & Kibana Helm Charts on Kubernetes**, accelerated repository search performance & enabled faster development workflows across US-wide distributed services
- **Orchestrated Python, AWS Lambda Auto-Remediation & Ansible API deployments for cross-functional teams**, enforced security compliance, standardized Docker container deployment & configuration, improving team delivery efficiency by 20%
- **Directed DevOps team migrating high-volume Kubernetes clusters to Karpenter**, executed AL2 → AL2023 Cloud-Init upgrade, & resolved GitLab Runner queue delays, resulting in faster deployments & measurable gains in developer productivity.
- **Integrated security-compliant Generative AI, VS Code plugin for AWS Workspaces**, enforced compliant LLM communication of sensitive data through an Application Load Balancer & minimized manual effort by 3+ developer hours weekly
- **Strengthened EKS & RDS multi-region high availability distributed systems**, boosted system resiliency & patching by 25%
- **Maintained IaC & CaC in Dev, Stage, Prod, & Ops environments**, lowered drift by 40% & ensured consistent deployments
- **Enhanced observability, logging, monitoring & alerting** with Splunk, Elasticsearch, Grafana, Prometheus & PrismaCloud for SLO/SLI Design, lowered response time by 10% & aligned improvements with DoD IL5 compliance roadmap
- **Contributed to blameless postmortems & root cause analysis**, closed observability gaps, & strengthened incident response
- **Engineered Python automation scripts for GitLab CI/CD pipelines for containerized workloads**, for same-day deployments
- **Directed on-call rotations & critical infrastructure upgrades**, sustained uptime, MTTR, & performance with zero incidents
- **Developed AWS disaster recovery training guide with failover simulations**, for reliable recovery of mission-critical systems
- **Migrated on-prem workloads to AWS GovCloud using Python**, achieved DoD IL5 & ISO 27001 compliance, enforced zero trust, performed Linux VM system tuning & refined deployment stability while integrating NoSQL & SQL database failover processes
- **Enforced Zero-Trust & AWS security principles**; IAM least privilege, KMS encryption, Security hardening, HTTP(S) security, TLS/SSL, Certificate Management, Okta SSO Authentication & embedded cloud security best practices into deployments

Agile, Ansible, Bash, Buildah, CI/CD Pipeline, Configuration as Code, Cloudwatch, Confluence, DNS, Docker, EC2, EKS, Generative AI, FedRAMP, Flux, Git, GitLab, GitLab Runners, GitOps, Grafana, Helm, JavaScript, Jira, Infrastructure as Code, Incident Response, Istio, Karpenter, Kustomize, Kubernetes, Linux, OKTA, Prometheus, Python, RDS, RHEL, SonarQube, Splunk, Terraform, Velero, Yaml

Work Experience

Tinker Air Force Base - *DevSecOps Engineer & Senior Staff Software Engineer* — Nov 11, 2019 - Oct 7, 2022
Active US Security Clearance (Top Secret) — Oklahoma City, *OK*

- **Engineered Groovy-based Jenkins, Perl, & Make CI/CD pipelines in Azure DevOps**, cutting build times by 65% & accelerating deployments through performance tuning, monitoring, logging, change management, & reliability engineering improvements
- **Automated RedHat virtualization systems with Bash**, evolved the Linux Administration stability & decreased manual setup time by 40%
- **Developed technical documentation for cross-functional teams**, increased knowledge transfer by 45% & shrunk resolution times by 25%
- **Partnered with cybersecurity teams to integrate Coverity SAST scans** into Azure DevOps & GitHub Actions pipelines, identified & mitigated 95% of critical vulnerabilities before production
- **Designed Linux Bash Scripts & documentation**, improved stability, System Configuration issues, & enhanced team expertise by 40%
- **Facilitated SAFe Agile ceremonies**, Capacity Planning, Sprint Planning, PI Planning, Stand-Ups, & Retrospectives, collaborating with cross-functional teams to align priorities & deliver commitments

Agile | Azure | Bash | Build | C | C# | C++ | Confluence | Git | Go | Groovy | HTML | Java | Jenkins | Jira | Make | Markdown | MS Azure DevOps | Perl | Scrum

Research and Development (R&D)

University of Central Oklahoma - *Data Analysis Research Assistant* — Aug 2018 - May 2019
Researched Cosmic Radiation using Muon Particle Detectors — Edmond, *OK*

- **Analyzed Muon particle datasets to determine statistical significance**, of cosmic radiation with 96.95% confidence using MATLAB
- **Identified actionable trends in radiation data across locations and elevations**, improving reliability of experimental reliability
- **Presented findings at a professional conference**, recognized for clear, data-driven communication and analytical rigor

Data Analysis | Excel | Fourier Analysis | Grant Proposals | MATLAB | Power Point | Presentations | Statistical Analysis | Time Series Forecasting | VBA

University of Central Oklahoma - *Statistical Analysis Research Assistant* — May 2017 - May 2018
Researched Human Population Growth Using A Physics Approach — Edmond, *OK*

- **Conducted statistical analysis on human population growth data**, disproved accepted models & improved accuracy forecasting to 99.98%
- **Analyzed large-scale population datasets**, in Excel and MATLAB, applying advanced statistical techniques to extract actionable insights
- **Identified critical flaws in widely accepted forecasting models**, enhancing predictive reliability and accuracy of analytical outputs
- **Developed and validated a high-precision predictive model achieving 99.98% accuracy**, enabling data-driven decisions

Data Analysis | Differential Equations | Excel | Grant Proposals | MATLAB | Nonlinear Regression | Presentations | Statistical Data Analysis | VBA

Education

University of Central Oklahoma — **Major:** *Engineering Physics*
Bachelors of Science (B.S.) — **Minor:** *Mathematics*

Achievements & Awards

Outstanding Contribution Award	Agile Program Increment Delivery	2025
Program Achievement Award	Agile Program Increment Delivery	2025
Program Achievement Award	Critical Outage Resolution	2025
Excellence in Incident Response Award	Cybersecurity Resolution	2024
Program Achievement Award	IaC Pipeline Automation	2024
Program Achievement Award	AWS Infrastructure and BigBang Integration	2024
Program Achievement Award	DevSecOps Pipeline Optimization	2023
Outstanding Performance Award	Agile Program Increment Delivery	2020
Outstanding Performance Award	Excellent Sprint Execution	2021

Additional Skills

Agile	Agile Methodologies | Agile ceremonies | Continuous Improvement | ITSM best practices | Kanban | Retrospectives | Scrum | Sprint Planning
AWS	Cloud-Init | CloudFormation | CloudTrail | CloudWatch | CodeCommit | DynamoDB | EBS | EFS | EC2 | EKS | EventBridge | IAM | KMS | Lambda | RDS | Route 53 | Route Tables | S3 | Secrets Manager | SSM | SNS | Subnet | Systems Manager | VPC
Architecture	Distributed Systems | Fault-Tolerant Systems | High Availability | Performance Optimization | Scalability | System Architecture
Cloud	AWS | Azure | Cloud-Based Deployments | Cloud-Native Applications | Hybrid Cloud | IaaS | Lambda | PaaS | Performance Tuning | Private Cloud
Collaboration	Cross-Functional Collaboration | Mentorship | Strategic Guidance | Stakeholder Communication | Technical Leadership
Databases	Aurora | Database Management | Data Modeling | DynamoDB | NoSQL | PostgreSQL | Query Optimization | RDS Clusters | SQL
DevSecOps	CI/CD Pipelines | Containerization | Docker | GitHub Actions | GitLab CI/CD | GitOps | Helm | Infrastructure as Code (IaC) | Kubernetes
Networking	ALB | DNS | HTTP | HTTPS | Load Balancing | Network Security | Nginx | Proxy Servers | Routing | TCP/IP | VPN | VPC
Observability	Grafana | Incident Response | Logging | Monitoring | Post-Incident Reviews | Prometheus | Root Cause Analysis | Troubleshooting
Programming	Ansible | C | C++ | Go | HTML | Java | JavaScript | JSON | LaTex | Object-Oriented Design | Python | Ruby | Shell Scripting | Terraform | YAML
Scope	High-Performance Platform | Infrastructure Management | Maintainable Applications | Resilient Systems | OnCall Rotations | Platform Architecture | Software Engineering | System Administration
Security	Cloud Security | Compliance Standards | IAM Least Privilege | KMS Encryption | Risk Management | Security Best Practices | Vulnerability Scanning | Zero Trust
Processes	Process Improvement | Operational Efficiency | On-Call Rotations | Blameless Postmortems | Risk Management | Incident Management